had for decades been governed first by the Left and then by a leader it accused of practising 'Muslim appeasement' to retain power was, in its view, a stark anomaly waiting to be corrected. As a BJP leader put it, "To win Bengal is not merely to win power. It is to come home."

The Road to Victory

In retrospect, there was no single defining moment, no dramatic wave, no visible rupture to suggest the BJP would win so emphatically. The party had spent a decade building something that would remain invisible until it was already done. To understand the scale of that transformation, consider that the BJP won just three seats and a vote share of barely 10 per cent in the 2016 assembly election. In contrast, the TMC won a staggering 211 seats and a 44.9 per cent vote share. The first inkling of change came in 2019, when the BJP emerged as Mamata's principal challenger in the state, winning 18 out of Bengal's 42 seats in the general election, 16 more than its 2014 tally. The TMC's tally, meanwhile, dropped by 12, from 34 to 22. Yet Mamata proved to be a doughty fighter, reaffirming her reputation as the Bengal tigress when her party won an astonishing 215 seats in the 2021 assembly polls, with a vote share of 48.5 per cent. However, the BJP, too, substantially improved its tally to 77 seats with an impressive vote share of 38.4 per cent, though much of the gains came from the Left cadre tactically shifting its vote, and a Congress wipeout, rather than any denting of Mamata's core base.

That momentum received a setback in 2024, when the BJP's tally dropped from 18 Lok Sabha seats to 12 in Bengal, even as the TMC's rose from 22 to 29. Worse, the BJP's national tally fell from 303 seats in 2019 to 240, forcing it to rely on NDA allies, such as Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party and Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal (United), to cross the majority mark of 272. Never one to give up, the party returned to the drawing board and decided to completely revamp its playbook in West Bengal. Boosting its confidence was the series of electoral wins in states following the 240-seat shocker in the Lok Sabha election. First, it snatched Haryana back from the jaws of defeat in the October 2024 assembly election. A month later, it engineered a massive victory in Maharashtra alongside its NDA allies. In February 2025 came the resounding win in Delhi, ousting Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal. By year-end, Bihar, too, was in. With every victory, the BJP edged closer to its final frontier—Mamata's Bengal.

Its electoral performances in Bengal since 2021 forced the BJP to face three truths: a demoralised cadre, hollow organisational structure at the grassroots and factionalism

The target was clear: to win the 148 seats required for a simple majority, not through the bluster that characterised its 2021 campaign, but with a quieter, more localised and methodical plan. The BJP that entered the 2026 campaign was very different from the one that had run 'Didi O Didi' or 'Pishi Jao' rallies in 2021. Back then, the saffron attacks had turned intensely personal, allowing Mamata to weaponise the BJP's barbs and campaign on a wheelchair, displaying her injured leg, amplifying her own 'Khela Hobe' narrative, driving minority consolidation in some constituencies to as high as 85-90 per cent.

Diagnosis, and Cure

Its electoral performances in Bengal since 2021 forced the BJP central leadership to introspect deeply, and come up with an unusually candid diagnosis. Three major problems were identified. First, the cadre in Bengal was demoralised. Years of political violence, booth-level intimidation and post-poll attacks had taken their toll, and party workers felt the central leadership had not stood firmly enough with them when it mattered most. Sec-

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



DECISIVE WIN BJP's Suvendu Adhikari after defeating Mamata from Bhabanipur, Kolkata, May 4

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY